



Chapter 4

User personas

Ages 12-15 · the deep end

Feelings get real, the algorithm gets loud, and the competition for a teenager's attention is now the most engaging content ever built. The trusted-adult gap is at its widest. India-segmented personas so Chapter 4 can hold a teen who has every reason to swipe away.

Now you're competing with the algorithm.

Earlier chapters competed with boredom. Chapter 4 competes with Instagram, Reels, gaming streams and the outrage-merchants, the most optimised attention machines ever made. At the same time, attraction becomes real, identity hardens, mental-health risks spike, and in India the board-exam machine swallows everything else. A teen will give a sermon about three seconds before swiping away. The bar is brutal, and pretending otherwise is how the games got shallow.

Four shifts from Chapter 3

SHIFT	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT THE DESIGN MUST DO
The algorithm is the rival	The competition is Reels and Tate, not a textbook; "educational" is a death sentence.	Be genuinely fast, real and shareable, or be ignored.
Feelings get real	Attraction, dating, sexting pressure and heartbreak are present tense now.	Consent and healthy-relationship content that is honest, not future-tense theory.
The rabbit hole opens	The manosphere and comparison culture actively recruit 12-15s by feeding real needs.	Inoculate: teach how the machine works, and meet the unmet need underneath.
Preachy equals dead	They detect and mock a lecture instantly; authenticity is the only currency.	Wry, real, a little deadpan; the brand's adult voice starts here.

Eight personas, three Indian segments, three roles. Each ends in design implications for the eleven Chapter 4 games: Body Confident, Bounce, Plan It, Outbreak, Green Light/Red Light, MythBuster Gender, Equalize, Stand Up, Firewall, The Rabbit Hole, and Reality Check.

High stakes, low patience.

The home segments carry through, but the pressures sharpen: a son being radicalised, a daughter being caged, a girl being married off, and the school staff trying to catch them all while the board exams loom.

PERSONA	ROLE	SEGMENT	IN ONE LINE	THE LEVER FOR DEPTH
Meera Joshi, 44	Parent	Metro	Her son quotes the manosphere at dinner.	Inoculate the boy; support the parent.
Sangeeta Rao, 41	Parent	Tier-2, joint family	Her daughter's world shrinks as boards close in.	Trust over control; fairness at home.
Sunita Devi, 36	Parent	Low-income	Relatives say her 14-year-old is "ready" to marry.	Keep her in school; equity and dignity.
Veer, 14	Teen	Metro	Angry, online, sold a story about being a man.	Meet the need, not just the myth.
Riya, 15	Teen	Tier-2	Top of the class, a secret boyfriend, Instagram.	Real talk on relationships and worth.
Kavita, 14	Teen	Low-income	Wants to be a teacher; her family wants a wedding.	Aspiration, offline, in her language.
Mrs. Iyer, 46	Educator	High-school teacher	Sees the crises, told to focus on boards.	Credible, low-time, incident-ready.
Farah, 31	Educator	School counsellor	Catching the kids who fall through.	Mental-health tools and referral.

THE FRIGHTENED BYSTANDER

Meera Joshi, 44

Banker · Mumbai · son Veer, 14 · a boy she's losing to a screen

"He told his little sister to 'get back to the kitchen' and laughed. That's not my son. Where did he learn that?"

HOME	Nuclear; both parents work; Veer (14) and a daughter (9).
LANGUAGES	English; Veer lives in English-language internet.
DEVICES	Own phone, gaming PC, Discord, headphones, closed door.
SCHOOL	Competitive private school; Class 9.
MONEY	Comfortable; the loss here isn't financial.

The last few months. Veer has gone from sweet to scornful. He repeats lines about "high-value men", "females", and feminism being a scam, picked up from streamers and short-form clips. He is also, underneath, anxious about his looks, his status and where he fits. Meera oscillates between confiscating the phone and tiptoeing around him. Both make it worse. She cannot tell if this is a phase or something that hardens.

What she wants

- Her thoughtful son back, without a war that pushes him deeper in.
- Something that reaches him directly, in a voice he won't mock.
- To understand what he's watching and why it grabbed him.
- To support without spying or confiscating, which only backfire.

The bias he's been sold

Not born in him; marketed to him. The manosphere offers certainty, status and belonging to an insecure boy, and charges him his empathy for it.

Feminism is a scam.**Real men dominate.**

The myth sticks because it answers a real ache. Beat it by answering the ache better.

Why she'd bounce

- Anything that lectures him about misogyny; he'll call it propaganda.
- A parental-control tool; he'll route around it and resent her.
- A childish tone; instant contempt, instant exit.

BACKFIRES FOR MEERA

A worthy anti-sexism module. Veer smells the agenda and it confirms his "they're all against men" story.

MAGIC TO MEERA

Something that hooks Veer on his own terms, shows him how he's being played for profit, and gives him a stronger idea of being a man.

Design implications

- 1 Never lecture a radicalising boy; inoculate by exposing the business model behind the outrage.
- 2 Meet the unmet need: offer real status, belonging and a confident, kind masculinity in its place.
- 3 Reach him solo, in a credible voice; no parental controls, no surveillance.
- 4 Give Meera a separate, calm "how to stay connected without a war" guide.

PROTECTOR TURNED WARDEN

Sangeeta Rao, 41

School clerk · Nagpur · joint family · daughter Riya, 15 (Class 10)

"I tell her to focus on boards and stay away from boys. Then I see how free her brother is, and I know it isn't fair. I'm scared, that's all."

HOME	Joint family; Riya (15), an older brother (18), in-laws.
LANGUAGES	Marathi / Hindi at home; English-medium school.
DEVICES	Riya has a phone "for studies"; usage is policed and suspected.
CARE	Board year; heavy coaching; reputation watched by the whole family.
MONEY	Modest; investing everything in the children's results.

Board year. Riya's world is narrowing to one exam and one rule: no distractions, especially boys. Her phone is checked; her movements are tracked; a glimpsed message would be a crisis. Meanwhile her brother comes and goes. Sangeeta knows the double standard is unfair, but fear, of gossip, of a "mistake", of the family's judgement, keeps her enforcing it. Riya, of course, has a boyfriend, hidden, and nobody she can ask anything.

What she wants

- Riya safe, respected, and through her boards without a scandal.
- To keep Riya talking to her instead of going fully underground.
- Honest guidance on relationships she cannot bring herself to give.
- A way to be fair to her daughter without facing down the whole family.

Why she'd bounce

- Anything that looks like it encourages dating during boards.
- Content the in-laws could brand as "spoiling" the girl.
- English-only or screen-heavy in a policed, shared house.

TOO RISKY FOR SANGEETA

A bubbly "dating tips" game. Unthinkable in this house in a board year.

The bias in the room

A girl's freedom as a risk, her reputation as the family's asset, control as love. The same household gives her brother the autonomy it denies her.

Girls must be guarded; boys can roam.

A relationship will ruin her.

Sangeeta wins when the product keeps Riya safe and talking, without daring the family.

MAGIC TO SANGEETA

A private, honest guide on consent, worth and pressure that keeps Riya safe and gives Sangeeta a fairer way to parent.

Design implications

- 1 Treat relationships and consent as safety and self-worth, defensible even in a strict, board-year home.
- 2 Name the double standard gently, so a fair-minded parent feels seen, not attacked.
- 3 Keep it private and bilingual; nothing that looks like "permission to date".
- 4 Help the girl keep a trusted adult, and help the parent stay that adult.

OPERATOR UNDER PRESSURE

Sunita Devi, 36

Daily-wage worker · rural Bihar · daughter Kavita, 14 (Class 9)

"My daughter is clever. But the relatives say she is grown now, and a good match won't wait. I am one voice against many."

HOME	Extended family in a village; several children; elders decide.
LANGUAGES	Bhojpuri / Hindi; little English; Sunita did not finish school.
DEVICES	One shared basic-smartphone; patchy signal; tight data.
CARE	Government school an hour away; an NGO runs girls' sessions.
MONEY	Marriage is seen as one less mouth; school as a cost with no guarantee.

This year. Kavita is fourteen, near the top of her class, and dreams of teaching. The relatives have begun the talk: she is "of age", a match is available, why waste money on more school. Child marriage is illegal and still common here. Sunita half-believes the relatives and half-believes her daughter. What she lacks is a reason, and a voice, strong enough to buy Kavita a few more years.

What she wants

- To do right by Kavita, torn between the relatives and her daughter's dream.
- A clear reason that keeping Kavita in school is the safer, smarter choice.
- Something Kavita can use that the family will not see as corrupting.
- Practical knowledge about safety, the law, and what's possible.

The bias she's surrounded by

A girl as a burden to settle, marriage as protection, education as a luxury that ends when puberty begins.

**She's grown, so she's ready to marry.
More school is wasted on a girl.**

Sunita is winnable. She needs evidence and allies, not judgement.

Why she'd bounce

- Text-heavy, English, online; none of it fits her life.
- Anything that openly shames the family or the village.
- Abstract "empowerment" with no concrete handle she can act on.

USELESS TO SUNITA

A slick urban app about "your rights". It speaks a language and a life she doesn't share.

MAGIC TO SUNITA

An offline, spoken, local-language story that shows a girl like Kavita staying in school, and gives Sunita the words to hold the line.

Design implications

- 1 Offline, audio-first, local-language; built for a shared basic phone and a hard life.
- 2 Make the case concretely: staying in school as safety, income and a real future.
- 3 Equip the mother and daughter with the law and with allies (NGO, school, helplines).
- 4 Centre dignity and aspiration, never pity or shame of the family.

THE LEARNER

Veer, 14

Metro · down the rabbit hole · "sold certainty by people who profit from his anger"

"At least someone's telling boys the truth. Everyone else just wants us to feel guilty."

Where he is, developmentally

- Mid-puberty; intensely status- and appearance-conscious; craves respect.
- Reward-seeking brain, impulse control still forming; certainty feels safe.
- Insecure and lonely under the bravado; afraid of being a "loser".
- Fluent in short-form video; the algorithm has learned exactly what hooks him.
- Pulling hard from parents; creators are his role models now.

CONFIRMS HIS STORY

An adult-voiced lesson on why his views are wrong. He's heard it; it proves "they're against us".

Why it grabbed him. The manosphere did not sell Veer hate first; it sold him belonging, a clear path to status, and someone who "gets" him. The misogyny came bundled in. He is not a villain; he is a target. Debating his opinions entrenches them. Showing him the con, and offering a better answer to "how do I matter?", is the way out.

MAGIC TO VEER

Content that respects him, reveals how creators farm his rage for money, and hands him real status without costing him his sister's respect.

Design implications

- 1 Inoculate, don't argue: teach the algorithm and the grift, so he spots the play himself.
- 2 Answer the real question, "how do I matter?", with a confident, kind masculinity.
- 3 Match the format he respects: fast, sharp, a little wry; zero moralising.
- 4 Make empathy a flex, not a weakness; give him status for it.

THE LEARNER

Riya, 15

Tier-2 · top student, secret life · "perfect on the outside, no one to ask"

"Everyone thinks I have it together. I have a boyfriend I can't tell anyone about and a phone full of edited girls I'll never look like."

Where she is, developmentally

- Board-year pressure plus a first relationship plus relentless comparison.
- High-achieving and anxious; her worth feels tied to marks and looks.
- On Instagram and Snapchat; absorbing filtered bodies as the standard.
- Facing real pressure to send photos; no safe adult to ask if it's okay.
- Carries the family's hopes and the household's double standard at once.

USELESS TO RIYA

A cheerful "love your body!" poster of a game. It doesn't touch the pressure she's actually under.

What she's navigating alone. Riya is exactly the girl adults worry least about and should worry more about: competent, secretive, and unsupported on the things that matter. She needs honest answers about consent, coercion, image-sharing and her own worth, in a place no one is monitoring, because asking at home is unthinkable.

MAGIC TO RIYA

A private, real conversation about consent, pressure and worth that takes her seriously and is safe from prying eyes.

Design implications

- 1 Get real about consent and coercion: sexting pressure, "if you loved me", the right to say no.
- 2 Take on comparison and filters directly; separate worth from marks and looks.
- 3 Private and unmonitored, with discreet exits for a policed phone.
- 4 Build the help-seeking muscle and route to real, confidential support.

THE LEARNER

Kavita, 14

Low-income, rural · fighting to stay · "a future against the clock"

"If I can just keep studying, I can be a teacher. I'm trying to give them a reason to let me."

Where she is

- Bright and determined; school is both refuge and ambition.
- Up against marriage talk, household duties, and a long walk to class.
- Reads slowly in English; sharp and curious in her home language.
- Her trusted adults are a teacher and an NGO didi, not the relatives.
- Carries shame the world assigns her, and a quiet refusal to accept it.

OUT OF REACH FOR KAVITA

An online, English app about "empowerment". It assumes a phone, a network and a life she doesn't have.

What she's up against. Kavita is the girl every statistic about dropout and child marriage is really about, and the girl who beats it when she has information, allies and a reason. She does not want rescue; she wants ammunition, to stay in school, to know her rights, and to convince a family that loves her but fears for her.

MAGIC TO KAVITA

An offline, spoken, local-language ally that knows her rights, fuels her ambition, and helps her make the case to stay.

Design implications

- 1 Offline, audio-first, local-language; usable in snatched minutes on a shared phone.
- 2 Arm her with rights and aspiration: the law on marriage, paths to a career.
- 3 Connect to real allies, teachers, NGOs, helplines, not just information.
- 4 Dignity over pity; treat her as the capable agent she is.

FACILITATOR

Mrs. Iyer, 46

Class 9-10 teacher · the one who sees it all and is told to teach the syllabus

"There was a photo going around last term. A boy talking like Tate. A girl who stopped eating. And I'm told to finish the portion."

Her reality

- Board classes; the entire system measures her on results, nothing else.
- Sees sexting incidents, manosphere talk, anxiety and self-harm up close.
- No mandate, no time and little training for any of it.
- Fears parent backlash if she wades into "those" topics.

UNUSABLE TO HER

A long, preachy, opinion-led programme. No time, and one complaint shuts it down.

What she needs from SwipeEd. Something credible and quick she can use in a fifteen-minute slot or assign privately, that handles the real crises landing in her classroom without becoming a controversy. A clear, calm resource on consent, online safety and respect that covers her with parents, and a discreet way to flag a child who needs the counsellor.

MAGIC TO HER

A short, fact-based, parent-defensible module on the exact crises she faces, with a quiet path to refer a struggling kid.

Design implications

- 1 Fit the board-year reality: tiny slots, zero prep, assignable for private play.
- 2 Be incident-ready: clear modules on sexting, harassment and online safety she can deploy fast.
- 3 Give her parent-facing cover and curriculum alignment for every sensitive topic.
- 4 Provide a discreet flag-and-refer path to the counsellor.

COUNSELLOR

Farah, 31

School counsellor · the safety net for the kids who fall through

"By the time they reach me, it's a crisis. I need something that reaches them earlier, and somewhere safe to send them next."

Her reality

- One counsellor for hundreds of students; demand far outstrips her hours.
- Handles anxiety, self-harm, body image, online abuse, and questioning kids with nowhere to turn.
- Walks the line of confidentiality, safeguarding and parent involvement.
- Trusted by students precisely because she is not their teacher or parent.

What she needs from SwipeEd. Early-intervention content that reaches teens before things become a crisis, with mental-health framing that is safe and accurate, and clear routes to real help. A tool she can recommend to a student between sessions, that speaks their language and never makes a fragile kid feel judged.

WRONG FOR HER

Cheery "wellness" content that trivialises real distress, or anything that could shame a vulnerable kid.

MAGIC TO FARAH

Accurate, gentle mental-health and safety content she can hand a struggling student, with safe, real referral built in.

Design implications

- 1 Build for early intervention: normalise struggle and coping before it becomes crisis.
- 2 Get mental-health content clinically right; never trivialise, never shame.
- 3 Route clearly to real help (helplines, counsellor, trusted adult) at the right moments.
- 4 Make it safe to recommend: private, judgement-free, in the student's voice.

What Chapter 4 must do differently.

Across all eight personas, one demand dominates: earn a teenager's attention against the best-funded attention machines on earth, and use it to inoculate, not to lecture.

PRINCIPLE	BECAUSE	SHOWS UP AS
Compete with the algorithm	The rival is Reels and Tate; "educational" gets swiped instantly.	Fast, real, shareable; production values that respect the bar.
Wry, never preachy	Teens detect and mock a sermon in seconds.	The brand's adult voice: honest, a little deadpan, still kind.
Inoculate, don't argue	Debating the manosphere entrenches it; needs feed it.	Expose the algorithm and the grift; meet status and belonging.
Relationships for real	Attraction, dating and sexting pressure are present tense now.	Consent, coercion and worth, honest and future-framed for SRH.
Body image and mind, central	Comparison, anxiety and self-harm peak at this age.	Coping, normalising, and clear routes to real help.
Private and autonomous	The trusted-adult gap is widest; phones are policed.	Solo, unmonitored, discreet; support parents without spying.
Equity under pressure	Child marriage and dropout are live at exactly 12-15.	Offline, in-language, dignity-first; tied to staying in school.
Help the system cope	Board tunnel, no mandate, one overloaded counsellor.	Tiny slots, incident-ready modules, flag-and-refer paths.

The same principles, on the eleven Chapter 4 games

GAME	THE DEPTH MOVE FROM THESE PERSONAS
Body Confident (g21)	Comparison and filters head-on; worth untied from looks; male body image counts too (Veer), not just girls.
Bounce (g39)	Resilience for board-exam pressure and failure; coping that is real, not a poster.
Plan It (g22)	Contraception as future-knowledge, health-framed to India's age-of-consent; shared responsibility.
Outbreak (g23)	STIs as facts not shame; testing and protection as adult self-care to come.
Green Light / Red Light (g24)	Consent and coercion for real: Riya's "if you loved me" pressure; healthy vs controlling.
MythBuster Gender (g25)	Counter Veer's intake: dismantle the gender myths the manosphere sells.
Equalize (g26)	Equality without the zero-sum lie; name the double standard Riya and Kavita live.
Stand Up (g27)	Harassment and bystander action; eve-teasing; impact over intent; safe ways to step in.

Firewall (g40)	Sexting, grooming and image-based abuse; you can stop, block, report; once sent, you lose control.
The Rabbit Hole (g43)	Veer's core game: inoculation against the manosphere and the outrage economy.
Reality Check (g28)	Porn literacy, misinformation and deepfakes; what you see online is not real life.

Next: the same persona lens for Chapter 5 (where identity and orientation come to the front), or a Chapter 4 game-by-game redesign built on this brief.